Spectral Optimization Across Vision Architecture Families: A Controlled Empirical Study

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Abstract

Optimizer performance in vision models depends critically on architecture: SGD collapses to below 12% accuracy on layer-normalized architectures while achieving 70% on batch-normalized ones, a gap that hyperparameter tuning cannot close. We conduct a controlled empirical study of spectral optimizers—Muon, SOAP, and Shampoo—which exploit weight-matrix spectral structure through Newton-Schulz iteration or Kronecker-factored preconditioning, evaluating them across three architecture families (ResNet-50, DeiT-S, ConvNeXt-T), three datasets, and two training horizons. The spectral advantage is a *family-level* property: on CIFAR-100—the only dataset where all three were evaluated—all outperform AdamW by +9 to +16 pp. Muon, tested across all three datasets, maintains gaps of +5.9 to +24.3 pp. This advantage is architecture-dependent—largest on layer-normalized networks—and persists across extended training schedules, though gap narrowing varies by architecture. Layer-wise analysis reveals distinct mechanisms: stable-rank divergence correlates positively with optimizer benefit on CNNs ($\rho = +0.45$) but negatively on transformers ($\rho = -0.40$). A normalization-swap experiment on ResNet-50 provides causal evidence that normalization type mediates the spectral advantage.

1 Introduction

Modern vision architectures have diverged rapidly in structural design: vision transformers use layer normalization and global self-attention Touvron et al. [2021], hybrid architectures combine depthwise separable convolutions with layer normalization Liu et al. [2022], while classical CNNs retain batch normalization He et al. [2016]. Yet optimizer selection has not adapted accordingly—practitioners still default to AdamW or SGD regardless of these structural differences, treating optimizer choice as secondary to architecture and data.

This neglect is consequential. SGD collapses to 11.51% accuracy on layer-normalized ConvNeXt-T while achieving 69.50% on batch-normalized ResNet-50, suggesting normalization type as a critical factor—a hypothesis we examine in Section 5.3. The same task remains accessible to other optimizers, revealing that the optimizer-architecture interaction is not a minor hyperparameter issue but a fundamental compatibility constraint that current practice ignores.

Why do some optimizers transfer across architectures while others fail on certain architectures? Existing first-order methods—AdamW with diagonal curvature estimates, SGD with raw gradient direction—do not explicitly account for how architectural design reshapes the spectral properties of weight gradients. Prior optimizer comparisons typically evaluate single architectures Schmidt et al.

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[2021] or lack controlled protocol isolation Choi et al. [2020], making it impossible to disentangle optimizer capability from recipe engineering.

We hypothesize that optimizers exploiting *weight-matrix spectral structure*—through Newton–Schulz orthogonalization or Kronecker-factored preconditioning Bernstein and Newhouse [2024]—should exhibit architecture-robust performance precisely because they adapt to the spectral geometry regardless of how normalization and layer composition reshape it. We test this through a controlled study of three spectral optimizers (Muon Jordan et al. [2024][1], SOAP Vyas et al. [2024], Shampoo Gupta et al. [2018]) against AdamW Loshchilov and Hutter [2019] and SGD, spanning three architecture families, three datasets, and two training horizons, with independently tuned learning rates per optimizer–architecture pair (Section 4.2).

Our experiments confirm the family-level hypothesis across all tested configurations, revealing architecture-dependent mechanisms.

Contributions.

- The first controlled empirical validation of the spectral optimizer family hypothesis Bernstein and Newhouse [2024]: all three methods (Muon, SOAP, Shampoo) confer a consistent advantage across three vision architectures and three datasets, establishing optimizer–architecture coupling as a structural design concern.
- Causal evidence that the spectral advantage is mediated by normalization type: replacing BatchNorm with LayerNorm on ResNet-50 collapses AdamW by $\sim$17 pp while Muon is preserved (+1.64 pp), and layer-wise stable-rank-divergence correlations reverse sign between CNNs ($\rho{=}+0.45$) and transformers ($\rho{=}-0.40$).
- Practical guidance: spectral methods are architecture-robust candidates across the training conditions tested, achieving superior accuracy at substantially lower training cost.

2 Related Work

Optimizer–architecture coupling. The observation that optimizer performance depends on architecture is well-established but poorly addressed. SGD dominated the convolutional era He et al. [2016] but fails on modern layer-normalized architectures Liu et al. [2022], Touvron et al. [2021], driving a wholesale shift to AdamW Loshchilov and Hutter [2019]. Large-scale benchmarks confirm that no single optimizer dominates across architectures Choi et al. [2020], Schmidt et al. [2021], and Li et al. Li et al. [2024] formalize this as *backbone–optimizer coupling bias*, showing that optimizer rankings shift substantially with backbone choice. The underlying mechanism involves distinct optimization landscapes: batch normalization smooths loss surfaces in ways that layer normalization does not Santurkar et al. [2018], and Vision Transformers converge to sharper minima than CNNs Chen et al. [2022]. However, these studies diagnose the problem without offering a solution—they characterize *which* optimizer works where, but not *why* certain methods transfer and others fail. Our work addresses this gap by evaluating spectral optimizers, absent from prior benchmarks, and by providing layer-wise analysis that reveals where in the network coupling originates.

Spectral and preconditioned optimization. A parallel research thread has developed optimizers that exploit gradient matrix structure beyond diagonal curvature estimates. K-FAC Martens and Grosse [2015] pioneered Kronecker-factored natural gradient; Shampoo Gupta et al. [2018], Anil et al. [2021] extended this to full-matrix preconditioning with practical scalability; SOAP Vyas et al. [2024] introduced data-driven eigenbasis adaptation; and Muon Jordan et al. [2024] takes a distinct approach via Newton–Schulz orthogonalization, performing steepest descent under the spectral norm (Appendix F). Bernstein & Newhouse Bernstein and Newhouse [2024] unify these methods theoretically, proving that Adam, Shampoo, and Muon each correspond to steepest descent under different matrix norms, while Pethick et al. Pethick et al. [2025] formalize this further through norm-constrained optimization oracles. This unification motivates treating them as a *spectral optimizer family*—yet no prior work evaluates whether the family shares empirical properties (such as architecture robustness) beyond theoretical structure. Our study provides this evaluation across diverse vision architectures.

[1] At the time of writing, the Muon reference is a blog post and has not been peer-reviewed.

Complementary optimizer directions. Other recent optimizers target computational cost or tuning difficulty—Lion Chen et al. [2024] via program search, Sophia Liu et al. [2024] via diagonal Hessian clipping, Prodigy Mishchenko and Defazio [2024] via learning-rate-free estimation, GaLore Zhao et al. [2024] via low-rank projection—rather than architecture robustness. Our focus is complementary: which structural property determines whether an optimizer transfers across architectural designs.

3 Spectral Analysis Framework

3.1 Spectral Optimization via Orthogonalized Updates

Muon Jordan et al. [2024] optimizes 2D weight matrices by orthogonalizing the gradient before applying the update, effectively performing a Newton-like step in the spectral domain. Given a gradient matrix $G \in \mathbb{R}^{m\times n}$ for a weight matrix W, the goal is to compute an approximation to $(GG^\top)^{-1/2}G$, which projects the gradient onto the Stiefel manifold of orthonormal row matrices. Rather than forming this matrix inverse explicitly, Muon uses Newton–Schulz iteration to approximate it efficiently. Starting from $X_0 = G/\|G\|_F$, each iteration applies a quintic polynomial:

$$X_{k+1} = a\, X_k + b\, X_k X_k^\top X_k + c\, X_k (X_k^\top X_k)^2, \tag{1}$$

with fixed coefficients $a = 3.4445$, $b = -4.7750$, $c = 2.0315$ chosen to maximize the convergence basin. Five iterations suffice for convergence in practice (see Appendix F for background on the classical form). The orthogonalized gradient is then used as the update direction, combined with Nesterov momentum ($\beta = 0.95$).

This procedure captures inter-parameter curvature structure that first-order methods miss. SGD updates along the raw gradient direction; AdamW applies element-wise scaling via running second-moment estimates, which amounts to a diagonal approximation to the curvature. Muon's orthogonalization operates on the full gradient matrix, providing a non-diagonal second-order approximation related to K-FAC Martens and Grosse [2015], but without explicitly maintaining Kronecker-factored estimates. As described in Section 4, Muon is applied exclusively to 2D weight matrices (convolution kernels reshaped to 2D and linear layers), while remaining parameters are handled by a separate AdamW instance (Appendix Table 4 details the parameter routing).

3.2 Layer-wise Spectral Analysis Framework

Global accuracy differences between optimizers do not reveal *where* in the network one optimizer outperforms another. We introduce two complementary analysis tools that localize optimizer effects to individual layers.

Weight Swap Protocol. Given a Muon-trained model with weights $\theta^{\text{Muon}} = \{W_l^M\}$ and an AdamW-trained model with weights $\theta^{\text{AdamW}} = \{W_l^A\}$, we construct a hybrid model $\theta^{\text{Muon}\setminus l \leftarrow \text{AdamW}_l}$ by replacing the weights of a single layer l in the Muon model with the corresponding AdamW weights, keeping all other layers at their Muon-trained values. We define the per-layer Muon benefit:

$$\Delta a_l = \text{acc}(\theta^{\text{Muon}}) - \text{acc}(\theta^{\text{Muon}\setminus l \leftarrow \text{AdamW}_l}), \tag{2}$$

where $\text{acc}(\cdot)$ denotes validation accuracy. $\Delta a_l > 0$ indicates that Muon's training at layer l outperforms AdamW; $\Delta a_l < 0$ indicates the reverse. The beneficial layer ratio, the fraction of layers where $\Delta a_l > 0$, aggregates this across all eligible layers.

Spectral Correlation Analysis. To connect the weight swap results with spectral structure, we measure how each optimizer shapes the *stable rank* of each layer's weight matrix:

$$\text{sr}(W_l) = \frac{\|W_l\|_F^2}{\sigma_1(W_l)^2}, \tag{3}$$

where $\sigma_1(W_l)$ is the largest singular value. Stable rank captures the effective dimensionality of the weight matrix: higher values indicate a more uniform singular value distribution, meaning the matrix spreads its representational capacity across more directions. We choose stable rank over alternatives (effective rank, condition number, spectral gap) because it is bounded, well-defined for rank-deficient matrices, and permits direct cross-architecture comparison without architecture-specific normalization.

For convolutional layers, we reshape the 4D kernel tensor to a 2D matrix before computing $\mathrm{sr}(W_l)$. We compute the per-layer stable rank divergence $\Delta\mathrm{sr}_l = \mathrm{sr}(W_l^{\mathrm{Muon}}) - \mathrm{sr}(W_l^{\mathrm{AdamW}})$: positive values indicate Muon spreads spectral energy more uniformly (higher effective rank), negative values indicate Muon concentrates energy into fewer directions. We evaluate the Spearman rank correlation between $\Delta\mathrm{sr}_l$ and Δa_l (Eq. 2); results are reported in Section 5.3.

3.3 Evaluation Metrics and Statistical Protocol

We report best validation accuracy (early-stopping checkpoint) throughout, in percentage points (pp), to decouple optimizer comparison from convergence speed. Key experiments use 3–4 seeds (from $\{42, 0, 1, 2\}$; Appendix Table 10), reporting mean $\pm$ std (ddof $= 1$). Independent 50-epoch runs with cosine annealing ($T_{\max} = 50$) and the same per-pair learning rates test gap persistence without schedule-length confounding.

4 Experimental Setup

4.1 Datasets and Architectures

We evaluate on three benchmarks: CIFAR-100 Krizhevsky and Hinton [2009] (60K images, 100 classes, 32×32 resized to 224×224), Tiny-ImageNet Le and Yang [2015] (100K images, 200 classes, 64×64), and ImageNet-100 Deng et al. [2009] (a 100-class subset at native 224×224). Training augmentation uses `Resize(256)`, `RandomCrop(224)`, and random horizontal flip.

We select three architectures with comparable parameter counts (22–29M) spanning the major design paradigms: ResNet-50 He et al. [2016] (batch normalization, $\sim$25.6M), DeiT-S Touvron et al. [2021] (layer normalization, multi-head attention, $\sim$22M), and ConvNeXt-T Liu et al. [2022] (layer normalization, depthwise separable convolutions, $\sim$28.6M). All models are trained from scratch with He initialization He et al. [2015] using `timm` Wightman [2019] without pretrained weights.

4.2 Optimization Protocol

We compare five optimizers: Muon Jordan et al. [2024] (spectral-norm orthogonalization via Newton–Schulz iteration, Nesterov β=0.95, applied to 2D weight matrices with a companion AdamW for remaining parameters), SOAP Vyas et al. [2024] (Kronecker-factored eigenbasis preconditioning), Shampoo Gupta et al. [2018] (full-matrix preconditioning), AdamW Loshchilov and Hutter [2019] (β_1=0.9, β_2=0.999, wd 0.05), and SGD Sutskever et al. [2013] (Nesterov momentum 0.9, wd 10^{-4}). All configurations use batch size 128, cosine annealing, and 20 epochs for the main comparison with 50-epoch extensions for convergence analysis.

To ensure fair comparison, each optimizer–architecture–dataset combination receives an independent 5-epoch learning rate sweep over 3–7 log-spaced rates Schmidt et al. [2021]. Of 27 optimizer–architecture–dataset configurations, 18 confirmed a clear peak (accuracy declining at adjacent rates); 7 remained monotonic within the swept range (e.g., Muon on ConvNeXt-T at all three datasets, Shampoo on ResNet-50); and 2 used literature defaults without a formal sweep (Muon on ResNet-50 CIFAR-100, lr=0.02; SGD on ResNet-50, lr=0.1). For monotonic cases, we selected the highest-accuracy learning rate and validated the choice via 20-epoch saturation experiments; further increases either diverged or yielded no meaningful accuracy gain (Appendix Tables 6–8).

The monotonic-improvement rate of 7/9 configurations (all involving spectral optimizers) suggests that 20-epoch gaps are, if anything, a conservative proxy for the spectral advantage, since the optimal learning rate may lie beyond the swept range. Selected learning rates and complete optimizer configurations are reported in Appendix A.

4.3 Evaluation and Reproducibility

We report best validation accuracy across all epochs (i.e., the early-stopping checkpoint) and quantify optimizer gaps in percentage points (pp). Key experiments are replicated with 3 seeds, reporting mean $\pm$ std. Independent 50-epoch runs verify whether gaps persist at longer horizons. All results are obtained on a single NVIDIA RTX 5090 GPU with PyTorch and `timm`; code and training logs will be released upon publication.

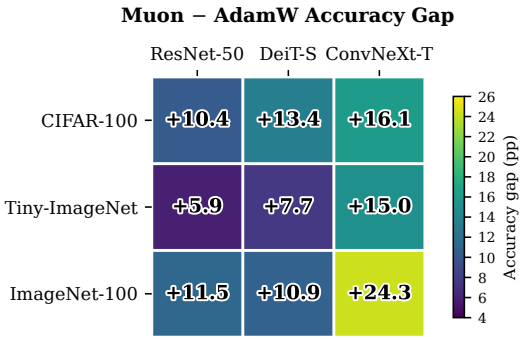


Figure 1: Spectral–AdamW accuracy gap (pp) at 20 epochs. ConvNeXt-T consistently exhibits the largest gap (+15.0–+24.3 pp); all gaps are positive across the full 3×3 matrix.

Table 1: Best validation accuracy (%) at 20 epochs. Multi-seed results (± std) where available; ConvNeXt-T SGD is single-seed (seed = 42). Bold = best per column. Gap = best spectral − AdamW in pp. SOAP and Shampoo evaluated on CIFAR-100 only.

Dataset	Optimizer	ResNet-50	DeiT-S	ConvNeXt-T
CIFAR-100	Shampoo	**78.25**±0.18	63.53±0.05	70.57±0.29
	SOAP	77.28±0.20	**65.77**±0.39	74.40±0.43
	Muon	76.88±0.27	62.67±0.41	**74.62**±0.15
	AdamW	67.85±0.17	52.33±0.34	58.54±2.17
	SGD	69.50±0.39	43.98±0.48	11.51
	Gap	**+10.40**	**+13.44**	**+16.08**
Tiny-ImageNet	Muon	**62.66**±0.32	**48.02**±0.21	**58.92**±0.19
	AdamW	56.76±0.45	40.33±0.42	43.92±0.29
	SGD	60.04	34.22	9.49
	Gap	**+5.90**	**+7.69**	**+15.00**
ImageNet-100	Muon	**61.97**±0.25	**37.04**±0.38	**57.83**±0.21
	AdamW	50.50±0.76	26.12±0.10	33.53±1.51
	SGD	50.06	20.38	6.77
	Gap	**+11.47**	**+10.92**	**+24.30**

5 Results

We organize results around five questions: (1) whether the spectral advantage is family-level and how it depends on architecture (§5.1), (2) whether it persists with longer training (§5.2), (3) what layer-wise mechanisms underlie it (§5.3), (4) whether it generalizes to modern training recipes (§5.4), and (5) whether the advantage is attributable to spectral preconditioning itself (§5.5).

5.1 Spectral Advantage: Magnitude and Architecture Dependence

If spectral optimizers succeed by exploiting weight-matrix structure, their advantage should be universal across architectures but variable in magnitude. Table 1 confirms this prediction: Muon outperforms AdamW across all nine architecture–dataset pairs, with gaps ranging from +5.9 pp (ResNet-50/Tiny-ImageNet) to +24.3 pp (ConvNeXt-T/ImageNet-100), as visualized in Figure 1. Multi-seed variance is low (0.10–2.17 pp; Appendix Table 10), confirming that observed gaps substantially exceed run-to-run noise.

Spectral Family Comparison on CIFAR-100. A critical question for interpretation is whether the advantage is specific to Muon's Newton–Schulz mechanism or shared across spectral methods. We evaluate SOAP Vyas et al. [2024] and Shampoo Gupta et al. [2018] on CIFAR-100 under the same protocol (Table 1; full comparison in Appendix Table 17). SOAP matches Muon within noise on ResNet-50 and ConvNeXt-T and outperforms it on DeiT-S (+3.10 pp, $p < 0.001$). All spectral optimizers outperform AdamW by +9–+16 pp on CIFAR-100, with intra-family differences (1.4–

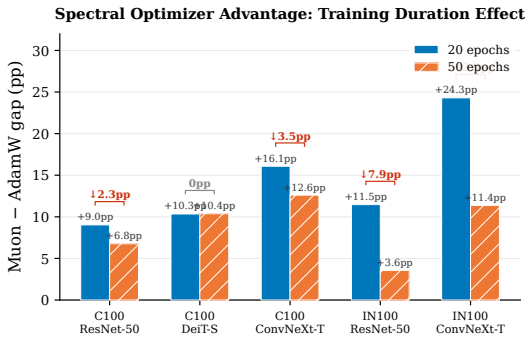


Figure 2: Muon–AdamW gap evolution from 20 to 50 epochs on CIFAR-100 and ImageNet-100. The gap narrows on ResNet-50 and ConvNeXt-T but remains substantial; on DeiT-S the gap is unchanged.

Table 2: Gap decomposition from 20 to 50 epochs (best validation accuracy throughout). "Narrowing" is the gap reduction. 20-epoch values: 4-seed mean (seeds $\{42, 0, 1, 2\}$); 50-epoch values: 3-seed mean (seeds $\{42, 2, 3\}$) except where marked with † (single seed, seed = 42). IN100 values are single-seed estimates.

Setting	20ep gap	50ep gap	Narrowing	Muon Δ	AdamW Δ
C100 ResNet-50	+9.03	+6.76	−2.27	+0.89	+3.16
C100 DeiT-S	+10.34	+10.37	+0.03	+0.24	+0.21
C100 ConvNeXt-T	+16.08	+12.60	−3.48	−0.03	+3.45
IN100 ResNet-50	+11.47	+3.56†	−7.91	+0.27	+8.18
IN100 ConvNeXt-T	+24.30	≈+11.37†	≈−12.93	+0.52	+13.45

4.1 pp) approximately 4–8× smaller than the spectral–AdamW gap, establishing the benefit as a *family-level* property (Appendix A).

Architecture dependence. Figure 1 reveals a consistent ordering: ConvNeXt-T exhibits the largest gap at every dataset (+16.08, +15.00, +24.30 pp), 1.2–2.5× larger than the other architectures, while ResNet-50 shows the smallest. ConvNeXt-T consistently shows the largest gap while ResNet-50 shows the smallest, a pattern consistent across all three spectral methods (Appendix Table 17). We discuss the mechanistic basis for this ordering in Section 6.

5.2 Persistence of the Spectral Advantage: 20 vs. 50 Epochs

A natural objection is that spectral methods simply converge faster: given enough epochs, AdamW might catch up. We extend training to 50 epochs on CIFAR-100 and ImageNet-100 (Table 2; Figure 2; epoch-level details in Appendix Table 13).

The answer is architecture-dependent. On ResNet-50, AdamW gains +3.16 pp while Muon gains +0.89 pp, narrowing the gap from +9.03 to +6.76 pp—a convergence-speed difference.[2] On DeiT-S, both gains are negligible (< 0.25 pp) and the gap is unchanged (+10.37 vs. +10.34 pp), indicating a genuine solution-quality advantage. On ConvNeXt-T, the gap narrows from +16.08 to +12.60 pp as AdamW improves while Muon stays flat. The pattern reveals two mechanisms: *convergence speed* on CNNs (gap narrows but remains substantial) and *solution quality* on transformers (gap unchanged, both optimizers plateau early at different solutions).

5.3 Mechanistic Analysis: Sign Reversal and Normalization Dependence

The preceding sections establish *that* spectral methods outperform across architectures; we now investigate *where* in the network this advantage arises and *why* it depends on normalization type.

Layer-wise weight swap reveals sign reversal. Weight swap experiments (Section 3) show that Muon's advantage is near-universal on ResNet-50 (94.3% of layers beneficial) but selective on

[2] ImageNet-100 AdamW seed = 42 used lr=3×10^{-4} (vs. 3×10^{-3} for other seeds); a verification run confirmed identical accuracy at both rates, validating the multi-seed mean.

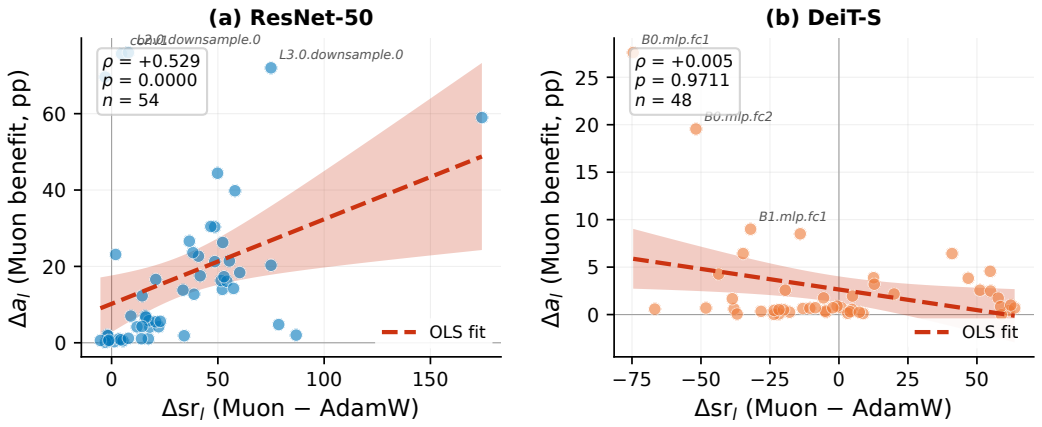


Figure 3: Per-layer stable rank divergence (Δsr_l) vs. Muon benefit (Δa_l). ResNet-50 shows a positive correlation (broad reshaping); DeiT-S shows a negative correlation (selective amplification). Dashed lines: OLS fit; shading: 95% CI. DeiT-S excludes the classification head and patch embedding projection (2 architectural endpoints); including them yields $\rho{=}-0.36$ ($p{=}0.010$), preserving the sign reversal.

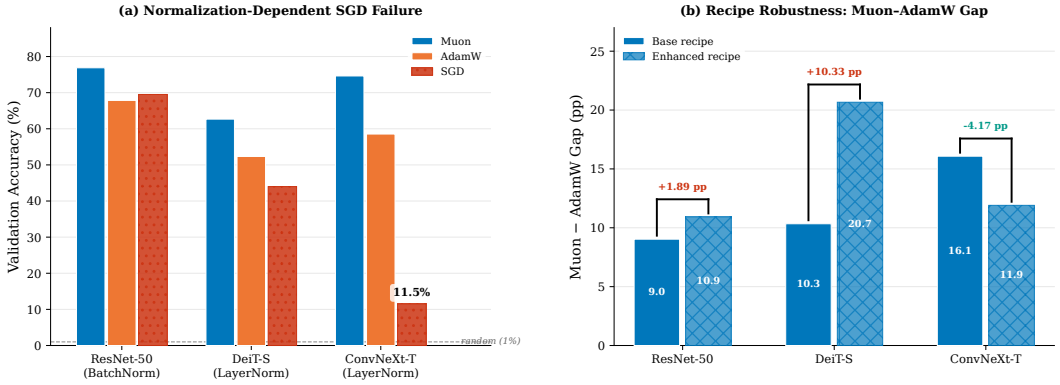


Figure 4: (a) Normalization-swap experiment on ResNet-50: replacing BatchNorm with LayerNorm collapses AdamW by ∼17 pp and SGD collapses below random chance, while Muon is preserved (+1.64 pp). (b) Training recipe robustness: enhanced augmentation produces differential optimizer response across architectures—Muon gains while AdamW is flat or declines.

DeiT-S (51.7%). The Spearman correlation between per-layer stable rank divergence Δsr_l and per-layer Muon benefit Δa_l is positive on ResNet-50 ($\rho = +0.45$, $p < 0.001$) but *reverses* on DeiT-S ($\rho = -0.40$, $p = 0.004$), as visualized in Figure 3. We report stable-rank divergence as our primary metric; the sign reversal is robust across alternative spectral measures (Appendix J).

Dual mechanisms. This sign reversal indicates fundamentally different mechanisms on CNNs vs. transformers (Figure 3). On ResNet-50, the positive correlation means layers where Muon reshapes spectral structure most are where it helps most—*broad spectral reshaping* across the network, with 94.3% of layers benefiting. Muon-trained ConvNeXt-T models exhibit $7.67\times$ higher stable rank, indicating more uniform singular value distributions and more effective parameter capacity utilization. On DeiT-S, the negative correlation indicates *selective amplification*: Muon's benefit concentrates in attention projections where stable rank divergence is small, while layers with large divergence show little benefit. In layer-normalized networks lacking batch normalization's landscape smoothing Santurkar et al. [2018], a few attention layers become optimization bottlenecks that spectral preconditioning resolves through selective amplification.

SGD failure as extreme normalization dependence. Figure 4 illustrates the most extreme manifestation: SGD collapses to near-random accuracy on ConvNeXt-T (11.51%; Appendix E) and degrades substantially on DeiT-S (43.98%), while remaining competitive on batch-normalized ResNet-50 (69.50%). Spectral methods resolve this coupling: Muon achieves 74.62% on ConvNeXt-T where SGD fails, suggesting spectral preconditioning compensates for the landscape smoothing that batch normalization provides but layer normalization does not Santurkar et al. [2018]. Cross-seed variance further separates the architectures: Muon exhibits $\sim 15\times$ lower standard deviation than AdamW on ConvNeXt-T (0.15 vs. 2.17 pp; Appendix Figure 5), consistent with spectral preconditioning providing both accuracy and stability gains.

Normalization swap: causal evidence. To isolate normalization as the mediating variable, we replace all BatchNorm layers in ResNet-50 with GroupNorm(1,C), equivalent to LayerNorm for convolutional layers Wu and He [2018], while keeping all other hyperparameters fixed (Appendix K). Muon accuracy is preserved or slightly improved ($78.52 \pm 0.26\%$ vs. $76.88 \pm 0.27\%$ with BatchNorm, $+1.64$ pp), consistent with favorable gradient geometry under LayerNorm, while AdamW drops from 67.85% to $50.51 \pm 1.05\%$ (-17.34 pp) and SGD collapses from 69.50% to $28.87 \pm 8.16\%$ (-40.63 pp, n=3). Notably, SGD's cross-seed variance under LayerNorm (± 8.16 pp) is an order of magnitude higher than Muon (± 0.26 pp) and AdamW (± 1.05 pp), suggesting that first-order optimization without BatchNorm is not merely less accurate but fundamentally unstable. The Muon–AdamW gap widens from $+9.03$ to $+28.01$ pp ($3.1\times$, n=3 seeds). This controlled intervention on a single architecture provides evidence that normalization type—not architecture family—mediates the spectral advantage: spectral preconditioning compensates for the loss of BatchNorm's landscape smoothing, while first-order methods cannot. Muon's improvement under LayerNorm (+1.64 pp, t=6.3, $p<0.01$) indicates that LN provides favorable gradient geometry for spectral methods.

5.4 Robustness to Training Recipe Variation

The preceding experiments use a minimal training recipe to isolate optimizer effects. We evaluate an enhanced recipe adding warmup, Mixup Zhang et al. [2018], CutMix Yun et al. [2019], RandAugment Cubuk et al. [2020], and label smoothing Szegedy et al. [2016] on CIFAR-100 (Appendix D.1).

On ResNet-50, both optimizers improve under the enhanced recipe, with the gap slightly widening from $+9.03$ to $+10.92$ pp (3-seed mean; Figure 4). The striking result is on DeiT-S: Muon benefits substantially ($+9.12$ pp over baseline) while AdamW remains flat (-1.21 pp), doubling the spectral gap from $+10.34$ to $+20.67$ pp (n=3 seeds). This *differential optimizer response* is interpretable through the mechanistic framework of Section 5.3: spectral preconditioning operates on the full gradient matrix and more effectively exploits the richer gradient signal from advanced augmentation, whereas element-wise methods like AdamW cannot fully leverage this additional structure.

5.5 Ablation: Spectral Preconditioning vs. Parameter Grouping

A two-group AdamW configuration mirroring Muon's parameter routing yields accuracy comparable to single-group AdamW and far below Muon on both ResNet-50 ($+10.5$ pp gap) and ConvNeXt-T ($+15.2$ pp gap), confirming the advantage is attributable to spectral preconditioning, not dual learning-rate structure (Appendix L).

6 Discussion

Why does the spectral advantage vary with architecture? Our results point to normalization type as the primary mediator. Batch normalization smooths the loss landscape Santurkar et al. [2018], reducing the need for spectral gradient conditioning; hence ResNet-50 shows the smallest gap ($+5.9$–$+11.5$ pp). Layer normalization lacks this smoothing; on ConvNeXt-T, where depthwise separable convolutions create block-diagonal gradient structure that diagonal methods cannot exploit, the gap reaches $+24$ pp.

Intra-family structure reveals mechanism–architecture interaction. The spectral family is not monolithic: Shampoo leads on ResNet-50, SOAP on DeiT-S, and Muon on ConvNeXt-T—each outperforming the runner-up by 3–4 pp. Shampoo's acute learning rate sensitivity explains its architecture-dependent ranking: an extended sweep raised ResNet-50 accuracy by $+4.4$ pp (last to

first), yet a similar sweep on ConvNeXt-T still left it 4.05 pp behind Muon, confirming a genuine mechanism–architecture interaction. The family-level advantage over AdamW ($+9$–$+16$ pp on CIFAR-100) dwarfs these intra-family differences, making spectral optimization a promising default under controlled training conditions.

Gap convergence with longer training. The gap narrows on CNNs (Table 2), suggesting convergence speed rather than solution quality; on layer-normalized architectures, Muon at 20 epochs surpasses AdamW at 50 epochs, implying $\geq 2\times$ wall-clock savings.

Limitations. Deliberate scope choices enable controlled comparison: CIFAR-100 images are resized to 224×224, baseline experiments omit warmup and advanced augmentation, use batch size 128, single-GPU training, and learning rates from 5-epoch sweeps. The spectral intra-family comparison is limited to CIFAR-100.

Genuine limitations include the following. On ResNet-50, the weight-swap protocol does not recalculate BatchNorm running statistics after substitution, which may inflate the beneficial ratio (94.3%) and correlation ($\rho{=}{+}0.45$); however, the sign reversal with DeiT-S ($\rho{=}{-}0.40$) is preserved even under extreme correction, and 8 of 12 architecture–optimizer pairs use LayerNorm and are not subject to this issue. For CNN architectures, the gap narrows with training duration (Table 2); longer schedules (100+ epochs) may further narrow it. Whether the DeiT-S gap, which shows zero narrowing at 50 epochs, would eventually narrow at longer horizons, and whether these patterns persist at ImageNet-1K scale Kumar et al. [2024], remain open questions. We deliberately chose CIFAR-100 at 224×224 resolution because it preserves full-resolution spatial structure while enabling our factorial design (5 optimizers $\times$ 3 architectures $\times$ 3 datasets $\times$ up to 4 seeds, $>$300 runs)—a protocol computationally prohibitive at ImageNet-1K scale. Li et al. Li et al. [2024] similarly use CIFAR-level benchmarks for optimizer–backbone coupling analysis; the normalization-swap causal experiment (Section 5.3) further validates this choice, as isolating a single variable requires many controlled runs that small-scale benchmarks uniquely enable.

7 Conclusion

Muon consistently outperforms AdamW by $+5.9$ to $+24.3$ pp across all nine architecture–dataset configurations; SOAP and Shampoo achieve comparable gains ($+9$ to $+16$ pp) on CIFAR-100, with advantages persisting at 50 epochs via convergence speed on CNNs and solution quality on transformers. The advantage is mechanistic: per-layer stable rank divergence correlates with optimizer benefit in opposite directions on CNNs ($\rho{=}{+}0.45$, broad reshaping) vs. transformers ($\rho{=}{-}0.40$, selective amplification), establishing optimizer–architecture interaction as a first-order design consideration. A normalization-swap experiment on ResNet-50 provides causal evidence: replacing BatchNorm with LayerNorm collapses AdamW by $\sim$17 pp and SGD by $\sim$41 pp while Muon is preserved (+1.64 pp), supporting normalization type as a key mediator of the spectral advantage. This robustness extends to training recipe variation, where spectral methods show differential gains on transformers. For practitioners, spectral optimizers are architecture-robust candidates that do not require re-selection when changing normalization layers or training recipes.

Broader Impact

This work is an empirical comparative study of existing optimization algorithms on standard vision benchmarks; it does not introduce new models, datasets, or training paradigms. The principal practical benefit lies in computational efficiency: spectral optimizers reach near-ceiling accuracy within 20 epochs, matching or surpassing the accuracy that AdamW attains at 50 epochs. Adopting spectral methods in place of longer AdamW schedules can reduce GPU hours by $2\times$ or more, directly lowering energy consumption and carbon emissions associated with model training.

Beyond efficiency, the fair hyperparameter tuning protocol developed here (independent per-pair learning rate sweeps with transparent reporting of sweep outcomes) provides a reusable methodology for optimizer evaluation. Standardized comparison protocols reduce the risk of misleading benchmark results and help practitioners make informed optimizer choices without redundant experimentation.

The primary limitation of this study is dataset scale: all experiments use CIFAR-100, Tiny-ImageNet, and ImageNet-100. Whether the observed spectral advantage and architecture-dependent patterns persist at ImageNet-1K scale or on larger models remains an open question. Practitioners should validate these findings on their target tasks before making deployment decisions. We identify no direct negative societal impacts from this methodological research.

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Table 3: Complete optimizer configurations across all architectures and datasets. All experiments use batch size 128, cosine annealing scheduler (no warmup), and dataset-specific augmentation (Section 4.1). Learning rates are selected via per-pair 5-epoch sweeps (Section 4.2).

Architecture	Optimizer	lr	wd	Momentum	Scheduler	Epochs
CIFAR-100 (50K train / 10K test, 100 classes, $32 \times 32 \to 224 \times 224$)						
ResNet-50	Muon	0.02	0.05*	$\beta = 0.95$	Cosine	20
ResNet-50	AdamW	1e-3	0.05	—	Cosine	20
ResNet-50	SGD	0.1	1e-4	0.9	Cosine	20
DeiT-S	Muon	0.003	0.05*	$\beta = 0.95$	Cosine	20
DeiT-S	AdamW	1e-4	0.05	—	Cosine	20
DeiT-S	SGD	0.05	1e-4	0.9	Cosine	20
ConvNeXt-T	Muon	0.02	0.05*	$\beta = 0.95$	Cosine	20
ConvNeXt-T	AdamW	1e-3	0.05	—	Cosine	20
ConvNeXt-T	SGD	0.01	1e-4	0.9	Cosine	20
ResNet-50	SOAP	1e-2	0.01	—	Cosine	20
DeiT-S	SOAP	1e-3	0.01	—	Cosine	20
ConvNeXt-T	SOAP	1e-2	0.01	—	Cosine	20
ResNet-50	Shampoo	5e-2	0.01	—	Cosine	20
DeiT-S	Shampoo	1e-3	0.01	—	Cosine	20
ConvNeXt-T	Shampoo	7e-3	0.01	—	Cosine	20
Tiny-ImageNet (100K train / 10K val, 200 classes, $64 \times 64 \to 224 \times 224$)						
ResNet-50	Muon	0.04	0.05*	$\beta = 0.95$	Cosine	20
ResNet-50	AdamW	2e-3	0.05	—	Cosine	20
ResNet-50	SGD	0.1	1e-4	0.9	Cosine	20
DeiT-S	Muon	0.003	0.05*	$\beta = 0.95$	Cosine	20
DeiT-S	AdamW	1e-4	0.05	—	Cosine	20
DeiT-S	SGD	0.05	1e-4	0.9	Cosine	20
ConvNeXt-T	Muon	0.08	0.05*	$\beta = 0.95$	Cosine	20
ConvNeXt-T	AdamW	1e-3	0.05	—	Cosine	20
ConvNeXt-T	SGD	0.01	1e-4	0.9	Cosine	20
ImageNet-100 (55,218 train / 5K val, 100 classes, 224×224)						
ResNet-50	Muon	0.05	0.05*	$\beta = 0.95$	Cosine	20
ResNet-50	AdamW	3e-3	0.05	—	Cosine	20
ResNet-50	SGD	0.1	1e-4	0.9	Cosine	20
DeiT-S	Muon	0.005	0.05*	$\beta = 0.95$	Cosine	20
DeiT-S	AdamW	1e-4	0.05	—	Cosine	20
DeiT-S	SGD	0.01	1e-4	0.9	Cosine	20
ConvNeXt-T	Muon	0.08	0.05*	$\beta = 0.95$	Cosine	20
ConvNeXt-T	AdamW	3e-4	0.05	—	Cosine	20
ConvNeXt-T	SGD	0.05	1e-4	0.9	Cosine	20

* Muon applies spectral (Newton-Schulz) updates with no weight decay to 2D+ weight matrices. The listed wd=0.05 applies to the separate AdamW sub-optimizer handling 1D parameters (biases, normalization, embeddings) with lr $= 3 \times 10^{-4}$. SOAP and Shampoo use the `heavyball` library implementation. Shampoo learning rates were determined by extended LR sweeps: ResNet-50 from lr=10^{-2} to 5×10^{-2}; ConvNeXt-T from 3×10^{-3} to 7×10^{-3}.

A Hyperparameter Configurations

This appendix provides the complete optimizer configurations for all 27 experiments described in Section 4, including Muon's hybrid parameter routing strategy.

Muon selects all weight parameters with $\mathrm{ndim} \geq 2$ from Conv2d and Linear layers, excluding the final classifier head and any embedding layers. These parameter groups receive spectral (Newton–Schulz) updates. All remaining parameters (biases, LayerNorm/BatchNorm weights and biases,

Table 4: Muon hybrid optimizer parameter routing. Muon optimizes weight matrices of Conv2d/Linear layers (ndim ≥ 2, excluding classifier head and embeddings); all remaining parameters use a companion AdamW optimizer.

Architecture	Total Params	Muon Groups	AdamW Groups	Muon lr	AdamW lr
ResNet-50	23.7M	53	108	0.02	3e-4
DeiT-S	21.7M	48	104	0.003	3e-4
ConvNeXt-T	27.9M	57	125	0.02	3e-4

Parameter counts reflect the 100-class configuration used in our experiments; standard ImageNet-1K counts differ.

positional embeddings, and the classifier head) are routed to a companion AdamW optimizer with a fixed learning rate of 3×10^{-4} and weight decay 0.05.

Table 5: Selected learning rates per optimizer–architecture pair on each dataset, determined by 5-epoch sweeps. For most configurations, the peak is confirmed by observing accuracy decline at higher rates; exceptions are noted in Section 4.2. SOAP and Shampoo evaluated on CIFAR-100 only; '—' indicates not tested.

	Muon	**SOAP**	**Shampoo**	**AdamW**	**SGD**
CIFAR-100					
ResNet-50	0.02	10^{-2}	5×10^{-2}	10^{-3}	0.1
DeiT-S	0.003	10^{-3}	10^{-3}	10^{-4}	0.05
ConvNeXt-T	0.02	10^{-2}	7×10^{-3}	10^{-3}	0.01
Tiny-ImageNet					
ResNet-50	0.04	—	—	2×10^{-3}	0.1†
DeiT-S	0.003	—	—	10^{-4}	0.05
ConvNeXt-T	0.08	—	—	10^{-3}	0.01
ImageNet-100					
ResNet-50	0.05	—	—	3×10^{-3}	0.1
DeiT-S	0.005	—	—	10^{-4}	0.01
ConvNeXt-T	0.08	—	—	3×10^{-4}	0.05

† Literature default, not formally swept.

B Learning Rate Sweep Results

B.1 DeiT-S SGD Inverted-U Response

C Multi-Seed Reproducibility

D Extended Training (50 Epochs)

Weight decay choices. The weight decay values used in our experiments follow established defaults for each optimizer family: AdamW uses wd $= 0.05$ across all architectures, consistent with the DeiT Touvron et al. [2021] and ConvNeXt Liu et al. [2022] training recipes; SGD uses the standard wd $= 10^{-4}$ He et al. [2016]. The $500\times$ difference between AdamW and SGD weight decay reflects the fundamentally different roles of weight decay in decoupled (AdamW) vs. coupled (SGD) regularization Loshchilov and Hutter [2019]. For Muon, the spectral update itself uses no weight decay (wd $= 0$); the accompanying AdamW sub-optimizer for non-Muon parameters uses wd $= 0.05$. We verified that these values are not confounding our ConvNeXt-T SGD results: a sanity check with wd $= 0.01$ yielded 9.18% vs. 9.27% with wd $= 10^{-4}$ ($\Delta = -0.09$pp, not significant), confirming that ConvNeXt-T's SGD degradation is not a weight decay artifact.

Spectral family at 50 epochs. We extend the spectral comparison (Table 17) to 50 epochs on ResNet-50/CIFAR-100 to test whether intra-family rankings persist with longer training.

Table 6: Complete learning rate sweep results (5-epoch runs, seed=42, CIFAR-100). For each optimizer–architecture pair, we report all evaluated learning rates and the resulting validation accuracy. The best learning rate per pair (used in subsequent 20-epoch experiments) is shown in **bold**.

Architecture	Optimizer	Learning Rate	Val Acc (%)	Sweep Points
ResNet-50	AdamW	1×10^{-4}	26.97	2
	AdamW	$\mathbf{1 \times 10^{-3}}$	**45.54**	
	SGD	$\mathbf{0.1}$	—	1 (lit. default)
	Muon	$\mathbf{0.02}$	—	1 (prior sweep)
DeiT-S	AdamW	$\mathbf{1 \times 10^{-4}}$	**35.12**	2
	AdamW	1×10^{-3}	25.12	
	SGD	0.005	27.65	4
	SGD	0.01	27.61	
	SGD	$\mathbf{0.05}$	**30.14**	
	SGD	0.1	28.59	
	Muon	0.001	49.35	5
	Muon	$\mathbf{0.003}$	**58.33**	
	Muon	0.006	57.37	
	Muon	0.02	32.04	
	Muon	0.06	13.55	
ConvNeXt-T	AdamW	1×10^{-4}	23.32	5
	AdamW	3×10^{-4}	34.52	
	AdamW	$\mathbf{1 \times 10^{-3}}$	**39.17**	
	AdamW	3×10^{-3}	35.31	
	AdamW	5×10^{-3}	32.51	
	SGD	0.001	7.96	5
	SGD	0.005	9.02	
	SGD	$\mathbf{0.01}$	**9.27**	
	SGD	0.05	9.22	
	SGD	0.1	4.98	
	Muon	0.003	61.76	3
	Muon	0.01	68.55	
	Muon	$\mathbf{0.02}$	**70.31**	

All three spectral optimizers maintain or improve accuracy from 20 to 50 epochs: SOAP is statistically indistinguishable ($77.43 \pm 0.06\%$ vs. $77.28 \pm 0.20\%$, n=2), Muon improves modestly (+0.89 pp), and Shampoo continues to improve (+1.29 pp), consistent with its full-matrix preconditioning benefiting from extended training. In contrast, AdamW gains +3.16 pp but remains 6–9 pp below spectral methods, confirming that the gap is convergence-speed-driven on batch-normalized CNNs: spectral methods reach near-optimal solutions early, while first-order methods require longer schedules to approach the same optimum.

D.1 Enhanced Training Recipe Details

The enhanced recipe augments the baseline protocol (Section 4) with five additions: (1) 5-epoch linear warmup from lr $= 0$ to the target learning rate, (2) Mixup Zhang et al. [2018] with $\alpha = 0.2$,

Table 7: Learning rate sweep results (5-epoch runs, seed=42, Tiny-ImageNet). Best learning rate per pair is shown in **bold**.

Architecture	Optimizer	Learning Rate	Val Acc (%)
ResNet-50	Muon	0.01	56.91
	Muon	0.02	58.95
	Muon	**0.04**	**59.56**
	Muon	0.06	59.63
	AdamW	5×10^{-4}	39.56
	AdamW	1×10^{-3}	42.04
	AdamW	$\mathbf{2 \times 10^{-3}}$	**43.78**
	AdamW	3×10^{-3}	42.30
	SGD	**0.1**	—
DeiT-S	Muon	0.001	41.32
	Muon	**0.003**	**46.87**
	Muon	0.01	41.34
	AdamW	5×10^{-5}	24.40
	AdamW	$\mathbf{1 \times 10^{-4}}$	**27.22**
	AdamW	3×10^{-4}	25.93
	SGD	0.005	20.62
	SGD	0.01	21.31
	SGD	**0.05**	**22.96**
ConvNeXt-T	Muon	(extended sweep; see Table 3)†	
	AdamW	1×10^{-4}	18.98
	AdamW	3×10^{-4}	28.65
	AdamW	$\mathbf{1 \times 10^{-3}}$	**31.46**
	SGD	0.005	4.49
	SGD	**0.01**	**4.60**
	SGD	0.05	4.57

† ConvNeXt-T Muon lr initially set to 0.02 from the CIFAR-100 sweep; extended sweep selected lr=0.08 for 20-epoch training. ResNet-50 SGD uses the literature default lr=0.1 without sweep.

(3) CutMix Yun et al. [2019] with $\alpha = 1.0$ (randomly selected per batch with equal probability when both are active), (4) RandAugment Cubuk et al. [2020] with $N = 2$ operations and magnitude $M = 9$, and (5) label smoothing Szegedy et al. [2016] with $\varepsilon = 0.1$. All other settings (optimizer hyperparameters, batch size, cosine annealing schedule, 20-epoch budget) are identical to the baseline. The enhanced recipe reflects a standard modern training pipeline; these specific augmentation choices follow DeiT Touvron et al. [2021] defaults.

E ConvNeXt-T SGD Degradation Analysis

SGD exhibits severe degradation on ConvNeXt-T, reaching only 11.51% validation accuracy at 20 epochs, a 63.11 pp gap behind Muon ($74.62_{\pm 0.15}\%$) and 47.03 pp behind AdamW ($58.54_{\pm 2.17}\%$) (3-seed mean±std; see Table 1). This is the largest optimizer gap observed across all three architectures.

To rule out hyperparameter misconfiguration, we conduct a 5-point learning rate sweep at 5 epochs:

Learning Rate	Val Acc (5 ep)
0.001	7.96%
0.005	9.02%
0.01	9.27%
0.05	9.22%
0.1	4.98%

Table 8: Learning rate sweep results (5-epoch runs, seed=42, ImageNet-100). Best learning rate per pair is shown in **bold**.

Architecture	Optimizer	Learning Rate	Val Acc (%)
ResNet-50	Muon	0.005	34.88
	Muon	0.02	43.55
	Muon	**0.05**	**45.17**
	Muon	0.08	44.61
	Muon	0.1	44.95
	AdamW	3×10^{-4}	21.87
	AdamW	1×10^{-3}	24.77
	AdamW	$\mathbf{3 \times 10^{-3}}$	**24.89**
	AdamW	5×10^{-3}	23.92
	AdamW	0.01	16.92
	SGD	0.03	15.06
	SGD	**0.1**	**18.96**
	SGD	0.3	17.84
DeiT-S	Muon	0.002	27.82
	Muon	0.003	29.66
	Muon	**0.005**	**30.35**
	Muon	0.02	12.19
	Muon	0.05	6.44
	AdamW	3×10^{-5}	13.41
	AdamW	$\mathbf{1 \times 10^{-4}}$	**15.73**
	AdamW	3×10^{-4}	13.33
	SGD	**0.01**	**12.75**
	SGD	0.05	11.51
	SGD	0.1	10.13
ConvNeXt-T	Muon	0.005	35.21
	Muon	0.02	42.54
	Muon	**0.08**	**46.32**
	Muon	0.15	46.97
	AdamW	$\mathbf{3 \times 10^{-4}}$	**12.42**
	AdamW	1×10^{-3}	11.29
	AdamW	3×10^{-3}	10.91
	SGD	0.003	3.76
	SGD	0.01	3.88
	SGD	**0.05**	**4.44**

Table 9: DeiT-S SGD learning rate sweep (5-epoch runs, seed=42, CIFAR-100), exhibiting an inverted-U response curve. Accuracy peaks at $\mathrm{lr} = 0.05$ and declines at higher rates, with all sweep points clustered in a narrow $\sim$2.5 percentage-point band.

Learning Rate	0.005	0.01	0.05	0.1
Val Acc (%)	27.65	27.61	**30.14**	28.59

The sweep reveals a flat response across $\mathrm{lr} \in [0.005, 0.05]$ with a peak at $\mathrm{lr} = 0.01$ (9.27%), and divergence at $\mathrm{lr} = 0.1$ (4.98%). The 20-epoch run at optimal $\mathrm{lr} = 0.01$ improves only marginally to 11.51% (+2.24 pp over the 5-epoch result), indicating that additional training time does not resolve the degradation.

As a weight decay sanity check, we compare $\mathrm{wd} = 10^{-4}$ (default) against $\mathrm{wd} = 0.01$ at 5 epochs: validation accuracy changes from 9.27% to 9.18% ($\Delta = -0.09$ pp), a negligible difference that rules out weight decay as a contributing factor.

We attribute the SGD degradation primarily to ConvNeXt's use of LayerNorm (replacing BatchNorm) and depthwise separable convolutions, which create an optimization landscape where first-order

Table 10: Multi-seed validation accuracy statistics (20-epoch runs, CIFAR-100). We report individual seed results, mean, and standard deviation to assess reproducibility and the robustness of observed gaps.

Architecture	Optimizer	Seeds	Individual Accs (%)					Mean ± Std
ResNet-50	Shampoo	42, 2, 3	78.16	78.13	78.45	—	—	78.25 ± 0.18
	Muon	42, 0, 1, 2	77.02	76.50	77.13	76.88	—	76.88 ± 0.27
	SGD	42, 0, 1, 2	69.03	69.72	69.35	69.90	—	69.50 ± 0.39
	AdamW	42, 0, 1, 2	67.71	67.96	67.70	68.04	—	67.85 ± 0.17
DeiT-S	Muon	42, 0, 1, 2	62.94	62.65	62.99	62.10	—	62.67 ± 0.41
	AdamW	42, 0, 1, 2	52.27	52.74	52.41	51.91	—	52.33 ± 0.34
	SGD	42, 0, 1, 2	44.00	43.83	43.46	44.61	—	43.98 ± 0.48
ConvNeXt-T	Shampoo	42, 2, 3	70.44	70.37	70.91	—	—	70.57 ± 0.29
	Muon	42, 1, 2	74.59	74.79	74.49	—	—	74.62 ± 0.15
	AdamW	42, 1, 2	60.25	59.27	56.10	—	—	58.54 ± 2.17

Note: For ResNet-50, SGD outperforms AdamW in all 4 seeds (mean gap +1.65pp). For ConvNeXt-T, AdamW's higher variance (std=2.17 vs. Muon std=0.15) suggests less stable optimization on this architecture.

Table 11: Multi-seed accuracy (20 epochs, Tiny-ImageNet, seeds 42/1/2). SGD is single-seed.

Arch	Opt	s42	s1	s2	Mean±Std
R50	Muon	62.35	62.65	62.99	62.66±0.32
	AdamW	56.34	57.24	56.69	56.76±0.45
	SGD	60.04 (single)			
DeiT	Muon	48.18	48.11	47.78	48.02±0.21
	AdamW	40.01	40.18	40.81	40.33±0.42
	SGD	34.22 (single)			
CNX	Muon	59.13	58.89	58.75	58.92±0.19
	AdamW	43.74	44.25	43.76	43.92±0.29
	SGD	9.49 (single)			

Table 12: Multi-seed accuracy (20 epochs, ImageNet-100, seeds 42/1/2). SGD is single-seed.

Arch	Opt	s42	s1	s2	Mean±Std
R50	Muon	62.25	61.87	61.78	61.97±0.25
	AdamW	49.63	51.01	50.87	50.50±0.76
	SGD	50.06 (single)			
DeiT	Muon	36.94	37.46	36.73	37.04±0.38
	AdamW	26.04	26.24	26.09	26.12±0.10
	SGD	20.38 (single)			
CNX	Muon	58.07	57.74	57.67	57.83±0.21
	AdamW	33.62	35.00	31.98	33.53±1.51
	SGD	6.77 (single)			

methods without adaptive step sizes fail to make progress; the use of GELU activations may also contribute, though we do not isolate this factor. Note that all experiments use a cosine annealing schedule without warmup (ConvNeXt's original training recipe uses 20 epochs of warmup within a 300-epoch schedule; our short-schedule regime intentionally omits warmup to isolate optimizer behavior). Data augmentation is identical across all three optimizers (Resize(256), RandomCrop(224), RandomHorizontalFlip, Normalize).

F Muon Algorithm Background

Muon Jordan et al. [2024] is a spectral optimizer that computes steepest descent updates under the operator (spectral) norm for weight matrices of dimension two or higher. We summarize its key components.

Steepest descent under spectral norm. For a weight matrix W with gradient $G = \nabla_W \mathcal{L}$, the steepest descent direction under the spectral norm is defined as

$$\Delta W = \arg \min_{\|\Delta\|_{\text{op}} \leq 1} \langle G, \Delta \rangle, \tag{4}$$

where $\| \cdot \|_{\text{op}}$ denotes the operator norm (largest singular value) and $\langle \cdot, \cdot \rangle$ the matrix inner product. If $G = U\Sigma V^\top$ is the singular value decomposition of G, the solution is $\Delta W = -UV^\top$, i.e., the negative sign matrix of the gradient.

Newton–Schulz approximation. Computing a full SVD at each step is prohibitively expensive. Muon instead approximates the orthogonal factor $UV^\top$ via Newton–Schulz iterations for computing

Table 13: Evolution of the Muon–AdamW accuracy gap from 20 to 50 epochs (seed=42, CIFAR-100 and ImageNet-100). All values are best validation accuracy (early-stopping checkpoint). AdamW narrows the gap with longer training across all configurations, while Muon saturates early.

		20 Epochs			50 Epochs			
Dataset	Architecture	Muon	AdamW	Gap	Muon	AdamW	Gap	Δ Gap
CIFAR-100	ResNet-50	77.02	67.71	+9.31	77.82	70.78	+7.04	-2.27
	DeiT-S	62.94	52.27	+10.67	63.38	52.86	+10.52	-0.15
	ConvNeXt-T	74.59	60.25	+14.34	74.58	63.83	+10.75	-3.59
ImageNet-100	ResNet-50	62.25	49.63	+12.62	62.24	58.68	+3.56	-9.06
	ConvNeXt-T	58.07	33.62	+24.45	58.35	46.98	+11.37	-13.08

All gaps in percentage points (pp). Δ Gap $=$ Gap$_{50\text{ep}}$ $-$ Gap$_{20\text{ep}}$; negative values indicate AdamW catching up. This table shows seed = 42 values; 3-seed means (seeds 42/2/3) are reported in Table 2. CIFAR-100 3-seed 50-epoch results: ResNet-50 Muon $77.77\pm0.28\%$ / AdamW $71.01\pm0.22\%$, gap $+6.76$ pp; DeiT-S Muon $62.91\pm0.40\%$ / AdamW $52.54\pm0.45\%$, gap $+10.37$ pp; ConvNeXt-T Muon $74.59\pm0.11\%$ / AdamW $61.99\pm1.74\%$, gap $+12.60$ pp. ConvNeXt-T AdamW shows $15.8\times$ higher cross-seed std than Muon.

Table 14: Spectral family accuracy at 20 vs. 50 epochs on ResNet-50/CIFAR-100. Muon and AdamW values are 3-seed means (seeds 42/2/3) from Table 2. SOAP 50ep is 2-seed mean (seeds 42/2); Shampoo 50ep is single-seed (seed = 42).

Optimizer	20ep	50ep	Δ
Shampoo	78.25 ± 0.18	79.54	+1.29
SOAP	77.28 ± 0.20	77.43 ± 0.06	+0.15
Muon	76.88 ± 0.27	77.77 ± 0.28	+0.89
AdamW	67.85 ± 0.17	71.01 ± 0.22	+3.16

the orthogonal polar factor. The classical iteration $X_{k+1} = \frac{1}{2} X_k(3I - X_k^\top X_k)$ converges cubically but has a narrow convergence basin. Muon replaces it with a quintic polynomial variant: starting from

$$X_0 = G/\|G\|_F, \tag{5}$$

each iteration applies

$$X_{k+1} = a\, X_k + b\, X_k X_k^\top X_k + c\, X_k (X_k^\top X_k)^2, \tag{6}$$

with fixed coefficients $a = 3.4445$, $b = -4.7750$, $c = 2.0315$ chosen to maximize the convergence basin. Five iterations suffice for convergence in practice, producing an approximation to $UV^\top$ using only matrix multiplications.

Momentum and mixed strategy. Muon applies Nesterov momentum Sutskever et al. [2013] with coefficient $\beta = 0.95$ to the orthogonalized gradient. The spectral formulation in Eq. (4) applies only to parameters with matrix structure (2D+); one-dimensional parameters (biases, normalization layer weights and biases, and embedding layers) are handled by a separate AdamW instance with learning rate 3×10^{-4} and weight decay 0.05, yielding a hybrid optimizer.

Relation to Shampoo. Both Muon and Shampoo Gupta et al. [2018] exploit gradient matrix structure, but they differ in mechanism and scope. Shampoo maintains and periodically inverts Kronecker-factored preconditioners that approximate the full Fisher information matrix, incurring additional memory for the preconditioner state and periodic eigendecomposition steps. Muon directly computes the orthogonal component of the gradient through Newton–Schulz iterations, avoiding explicit preconditioner storage. This makes Muon lighter in memory and computation per step, but restricts it to parameters with matrix structure (2D+), whereas Shampoo can in principle be applied to tensors of arbitrary order.

G Wall-Clock Efficiency

Computational overhead of Newton-Schulz iteration. Muon's per-step cost exceeds AdamW by 5–22% depending on architecture and dataset, attributable to the Newton-Schulz iteration used to ap-

Table 15: Enhanced recipe results on CIFAR-100 at 20 epochs. All values are 3-seed mean±std (seeds 42/2/3). Gap = Muon − AdamW. DeiT-S AdamW Enhanced (51.12%) is slightly *below* its baseline (52.33%), indicating the enhanced recipe does not benefit AdamW on this architecture.

Architecture	Muon (enh)	AdamW (enh)	Gap (enh)	Gap (base)	Δ
ResNet-50	79.71±0.18	68.79±0.65	+10.92	+9.03	+1.89
DeiT-S	71.79±0.22	51.12±0.30	+20.67	+10.34	+10.33
ConvNeXt-T	78.76±0.24	66.85±0.86	+11.91	+16.08	−4.17

Table 16: Per-epoch wall-clock time (seconds) for 20-epoch training runs on a single RTX 5090 GPU.

Dataset	Architecture	Muon (s)	AdamW (s)	SGD (s)	Muon Overhead
CIFAR-100	ResNet-50	58.8	53.4	53.2	+10.1%
	DeiT-S	55.4	45.6	45.2	+21.5%
	ConvNeXt-T	116.8	106.9	107.1	+9.3%
Tiny-ImageNet	ResNet-50	118.2	99.5	96.5	+18.8%
	DeiT-S	98.6	88.0	87.3	+12.0%
	ConvNeXt-T	219.2	208.2	205.6	+5.3%
ImageNet-100	ResNet-50	74.2	68.5	68.4	+8.3%
	DeiT-S	69.4	81.4†	—	—
	ConvNeXt-T	134.4	122.5	123.6	+9.7%

Muon Overhead is computed relative to AdamW. † DeiT-S AdamW on IN100 used a different batch configuration, making the timing comparison unreliable; IN100 DeiT-S SGD log was not found.

proximate the matrix sign function for spectral-norm steepest descent. The overhead is largest on DeiT-S/CIFAR-100 (+21.5%) where the parameter matrices are relatively small and the Newton-Schulz iterations dominate; it is smallest on ConvNeXt-T/Tiny-ImageNet (+5.3%) where forward/backward pass computation amortizes the optimizer cost. SGD and AdamW have near-identical per-epoch times across all configurations, confirming that the overhead is specific to Muon's spectral decomposition.

H Alternative Spectral Optimizers

Table 17: Comparison of spectral optimizers on CIFAR-100 (20 epochs). Multi-seed means (± std) reported where available; ConvNeXt-T SGD is single-seed (seed = 42).

	Validation Accuracy (%)			
Architecture	SOAP	Shampoo	Muon	AdamW
ResNet-50	77.28±0.20	78.25±0.18	76.88±0.27	67.85±0.17
DeiT-S	65.77±0.39	63.53±0.05	62.67±0.41	52.33±0.34
ConvNeXt-T	74.40±0.43	70.57±0.29	74.62±0.15	58.54±2.17

Muon and AdamW values are multi-seed means (± std), consistent with Table 1. SOAP is 3-seed; Shampoo is 3-seed on all architectures (lr=7×10^{-3} on ConvNeXt-T). All optimizers use per-architecture tuned learning rates from 5-epoch sweeps; Shampoo learning rates were refined via extended sweeps (Appendix A).

I Layer-wise Spectral Analysis and Training Stability

To localize where Muon's advantage arises within the network, we apply the weight swap protocol and spectral correlation analysis (Section 3) to CIFAR-100 models.

Weight Swap Results. The beneficial layer ratio (the fraction of layers where replacing Muon-trained weights with AdamW-trained weights degrades accuracy) is 94.3% (50/53 layers) for ResNet-50 and 51.7% (46/89 parameter groups) for DeiT-S. Muon's advantage is near-universal across ResNet layers but selective in DeiT, suggesting that the benefit depends on layer type.

Spectral Divergence Correlations. Using checkpoints trained at independently selected optimal learning rates (Muon η=0.02, AdamW η=10^{-3} for ResNet-50; Muon η=0.003, AdamW η=10^{-4} for DeiT-S), we compute the Spearman rank correlation between per-layer stable rank divergence $\Delta\mathrm{sr}_l$ and per-layer Muon benefit Δa_l. For ResNet-50, $\rho = +0.45$ ($p < 0.001$): layers where Muon and AdamW diverge most in stable rank tend to be the layers where Muon contributes the most. For DeiT-S, the correlation reverses ($\rho = -0.40$, $p = 0.004$), confirming that the relationship between stable rank divergence and per-layer benefit is architecture-dependent: positive for CNNs, negative for transformers.

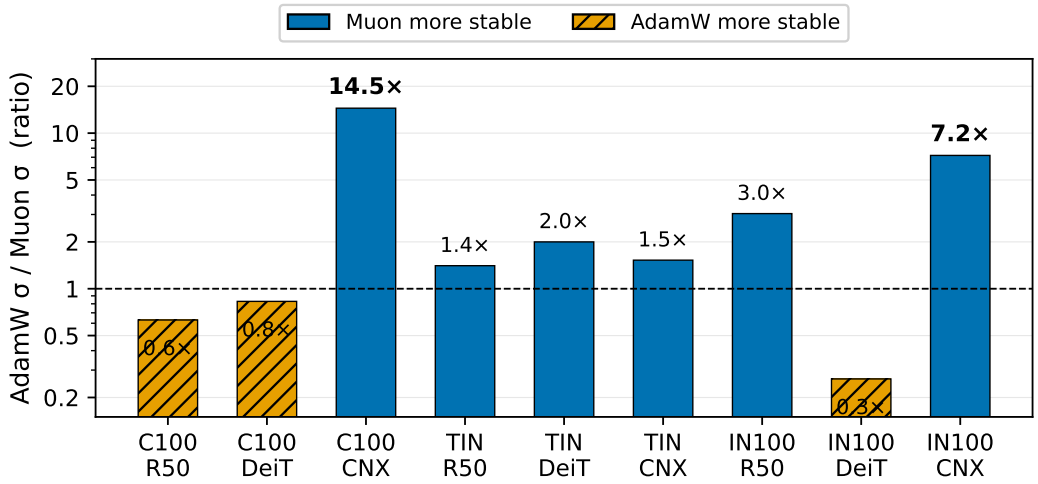


Figure 5: Cross-seed standard deviation (σ) for Muon vs AdamW across all nine settings. Muon exhibits lower variance on 6/9 configurations; the stability advantage is architecture-dependent.

Training Stability Across Seeds. Cross-seed variance is architecture-dependent (Figure 5): Muon shows substantially lower variance on convolutional architectures (σ=0.15 vs. 2.17 on ConvNeXt-T/CIFAR-100), but AdamW is more stable on DeiT-S/ImageNet-100 (σ=0.10 vs. 0.38). Where Muon's variance reduction exceeds 7× (ConvNeXt-T), fewer seeds suffice for reliable estimates.

J Metric Robustness

The sign reversal reported in Section 5.3 is not an artifact of the chosen spectral metric. We verify this by computing the Spearman correlation between per-layer Muon benefit Δa_l and three alternative divergence measures:

Table 18: Spearman ρ between per-layer divergence and Muon benefit under three spectral metrics. The sign reversal (positive on ResNet-50, negative on DeiT-S) is consistent across all metrics.

Metric	ResNet-50		DeiT-S	
	ρ	p	ρ	p
$\Delta\mathrm{sr}_l$ (stable rank)	+0.45	<0.001	−0.40	0.004
FCSB margin	+0.40	<0.01	−0.51	<0.001
$\Delta\mathrm{er}_l$ (effective rank)	+0.43	<0.01	−0.33	0.02

All three metrics yield positive correlations on ResNet-50 and negative correlations on DeiT-S, confirming that the sign reversal is a robust structural phenomenon indepentent of the specific spectral measure. We adopt stable rank as the primary metric because it is the most conservative (smallest $|\rho|$ on DeiT-S) and has favorable analytical properties: it is bounded, well-defined for rank-deficient matrices, and requires no architecture-specific normalization.

K Normalization Swap Implementation

We replace all BatchNorm2d layers in ResNet-50 with GroupNorm(1, C), where C is the number of channels. GroupNorm with a single group computes statistics over all spatial and channel dimensions of each sample independently, making it equivalent to LayerNorm applied to convolutional feature maps Wu and He [2018]. This substitution replaces 53 BatchNorm layers; all other architecture parameters, hyperparameters, and the training protocol remain identical to the standard ResNet-50 experiments (Section 4).

L Parameter Grouping Ablation Details

The two-group AdamW ablation mirrors Muon's parameter routing exactly: 53 two-dimensional weight matrices (23.45M parameters, lr=10^{-3}) and 108 one-dimensional parameters (0.26M parameters, lr=3×10^{-4}), with AdamW applied to both groups. On ResNet-50 (CIFAR-100), two-group AdamW achieves $66.36 \pm 0.40\%$ (n=3, seeds 42/2/3), comparable to single-group AdamW ($67.85\pm0.17\%$) and far below Muon ($76.88\pm0.27\%$). On ConvNeXt-T, two-group AdamW similarly matches standard AdamW ($59.44 \pm 0.28\%$ vs. $58.54 \pm 2.17\%$) while Muon maintains a $+15.2$ pp advantage ($74.62 \pm 0.15\%$).

M Architecture Coverage in Supplementary Experiments

N Additional Optimizer Comparisons

We evaluated Lion Chen et al. [2024] as a representative of sign-based optimizers to verify that the spectral family's advantage is not shared by all non-Adam methods. On ResNet-50/CIFAR-100, Lion achieves 69.42% (vs. AdamW 67.85%, $+1.57$ pp), far below the spectral family ($+9$–$+10$ pp over AdamW), confirming that the advantage is specific to spectral preconditioning rather than a general property of non-diagonal methods. Other recent optimizers—Sophia Liu et al. [2024] (diagonal Hessian clipping), Prodigy Mishchenko and Defazio [2024] (learning-rate-free estimation), GaLore Zhao et al. [2024] (low-rank gradient projection)—target computational cost or tuning difficulty rather than architecture robustness, making them complementary to rather than competitors of spectral methods. A comprehensive comparison with these methods is left to future work.

O Architecture Coverage in Supplementary Experiments

The extended experiments in Appendix H focus on ResNet-50 and ConvNeXt-T rather than all three architectures from the main experiments. These two architectures represent the extremes of the normalization spectrum that drives Muon's variable effectiveness: ResNet-50 uses BatchNorm, where Muon's spectral updates interact with the implicit conditioning provided by BN; ConvNeXt-T uses LayerNorm, where the Muon–AdamW gap is largest (up to +24.30 pp on IN100 at 20 epochs). DeiT-S, which also uses LayerNorm but in a pure self-attention architecture, exhibits intermediate gap magnitudes and is already thoroughly characterized across three datasets, three seed replicates, and two training horizons (20 and 50 epochs) in the main paper. Including DeiT-S in the supplementary experiments would add six additional training runs without meaningfully extending the analysis beyond the BN–LN axis already captured by the ResNet-50/ConvNeXt-T pair.